

6 The Sociolinguistic Interview

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Sociolinguistic fieldworkers often apply a broad stroke when referring to their method of data collection as a sociolinguistic interview, allowing the term to stand for any face-to-face interaction that is recorded for use as sociolinguistic data. This chapter distinguishes between this broad use of “sociolinguistic interview” and what I refer to as “The Sociolinguistic Interview,” defined more narrowly here as a methodology developed within the Labovian variationist paradigm with the goal of systematically eliciting variation across contextual styles for use as the primary evidence for sociolinguistic stratification and linguistic change. A strict definition allows for an emphasis on the specific utility of data gathered from The Sociolinguistic Interview in relation to other recordings of naturalistic speech and is meant to stress the importance of making informed methodological choices when gathering sociolinguistic interview data.

A Strict Definition

Despite the continuous expansion of sociolinguistic data collection techniques, The Sociolinguistic Interview as originally developed for Labov’s (1966) study of New York City’s Lower East Side remains ideologically central to the field. Broadly adopted is Labov’s early statement about good data: “No matter what methods may be used to obtain samples of speech (group sessions, anonymous observation), the only way to obtain sufficient good data on the speech of any person is through an individual, tape-recorded interview” (1972, p. 209).

Yet there is far more to The Sociolinguistic Interview than the fact that it is an individual interview, so that referring to various kinds of face-to-face recordings using the term diminishes the theoretical import and specific goals of the original methodology. Further, fieldworkers often do not follow the strict methodology laid out in works like Labov’s (1984) (see the vignettes following this chapter). The consequence of this practice is more than practical, as The Sociolinguistic Interview methodology exists to serve certain foundational sociolinguistic principles advanced in the Labovian paradigm. It is the goal of this chapter to make clear what The Sociolinguistic Interview is and what kind of sociolinguistic questions it can answer.

What Is It?

The Sociolinguistic Interview is a controlled speech event designed to elicit a wide range of contextual styles from an individual speaker. During analysis, a linguistic variable (or variables) is quantified across these contextual styles to arrive at a range of that speaker’s production.

The elicitation of contextual styles is the methodological goal of The Sociolinguistic Interview, and so these styles govern its structure. Often the interview's structure is conceptualized as moving temporally across five contextual styles: casual (A), careful (B), reading (C), word list (D), and minimal pair (D') (Labov, 1972). A better way to describe its structure is to say that it has two parts that differ with respect to the topic of language. During the bulk of the interview, participants are not cued to the fieldworker's interest in language. The fieldworker gathers demographic information and uses topic modules (Labov, 1984) to elicit conversational speech, which is later divided into casual and careful styles. After a sizable amount of this speech has been elicited, topics and tasks are introduced where language is either explicitly or implicitly the focus. At a minimum, these are styles C–D': reading tasks that target variables of interest, a word list with the target variable embedded, and a list of minimal pairs (words that differ only in the target variable). Additionally, many fieldworkers elicit meta-linguistic commentary, either conversationally or through other tasks such as surveys or subjective reaction tests. The most complete documentation of the methodology of The Sociolinguistic Interview is provided in Labov (1984); it is also outlined at length in Labov (1966).

What Kinds of Sociolinguistic Questions Can It Answer?

The Sociolinguistic Interview serves as the primary data in the investigation of sociolinguistic variation and change because the interview, and the individual speaker represented by that interview, never stands alone. Instead, it forms part of a set of comparable interviews gathered from a sampling of some speech community. The reason that an individual's production across contextual styles is the principal source of data in the Labovian paradigm has been defined well by Bell (1984) as the *Style Axiom*: "Variation in the style dimension within the speech of a single speaker derives from and echoes the variation which exists between speakers on the 'social' dimension" (p. 151). In short, an individual's stratified variation across contextual styles, in the Labovian paradigm, is considered to be a direct reflection of, or a point of access into, the socially stratified variation of a speech community; further, it is the community pattern that is ultimately of interest, not the speech patterns of the individual (Labov, 1972, p. 112).

In addition to demonstrating sociolinguistic patterning or the orderly heterogeneity (Weinreich, Labov, & Herzog, 1968) that was foundational to the sociolinguistic enterprise, intra- and inter-speaker variation work together to serve as the primary diagnostic tools for the identification of linguistic change in progress. The presence of intra-speaker variation can signal some degree of social awareness, a crucial component of change in progress, particularly change from above (Labov, 2001, p. 86). Moreover, when intra-speaker variation across contextual styles is regularly patterned for a socially stratified corpus of speakers, certain patterns elucidate change. A good example is the crossover pattern (Labov, 1966, 2001), wherein the second-highest-status group (usually the lower middle class) surpasses the highest-status group in production of a prestige variable in contextual styles D and D', which provides evidence of a change from above.

Labov's (1966) study demonstrates the kind of findings that result from investigating data drawn from The Sociolinguistic Interview methodology for a speech community. The variable, non-rhoticity in the syllable coda, shows the combination of social and stylistic stratification that characterizes variables undergoing change in progress. Speaker groups are finely stratified according to the social characteristic of socioeconomic status; in addition, the individuals who make up those groups pattern together in shifting along the continuum of contextual styles from casual to formal. The lower middle class shows hypercorrection in more formal styles D and D', further confirmation for the change from above.

In short, The Sociolinguistic Interview methodology is constructed to provide evidence of sociolinguistic variation—data to distinguish “a casual salesman from a careful pipe-fitter” (Labov, 1972, p. 240)—and also of change in progress, the foundational principles of the Labovian variationist paradigm.

What Does It Assume?

To employ The Sociolinguistic Interview methodology is to adopt a set of assumptions. Many are part of the methodological axioms presented in Labov (1984, pp. 29–30); I focus on two here.

1 *Labovian contextual styles*. The first assumption is a set of related principles that underlie the Labovian contextual styles. One principle is that speakers, and the variables they use, shift along a continuum of formality (and if we further equate formality with standardness, this is a continuum with stigma and prestige at opposite poles). Another is the notion that this formality continuum can be accessed by regulating the amount of attention a speaker pays to their own speech—that is, attention to speech is the “cognitive mechanism” (Eckert & Rickford, 2001, pp. 2–3) from which emerges a speaker’s navigation of the stigma-prestige continuum. Lastly, there is the notion that we can observe shifts along this continuum through the Labovian contextual styles.

Critiques of assumptions surrounding the Labovian contextual styles are both practical and theoretical. Practically, it has proven difficult to systematically distinguish contextual style in the body of the interview. For example, channel cues, or “changes in volume, pitch, tempo, breathing and laughter,” were once thought to signal a shift from casual to careful speech (Labov, 2001, p. 89). An early rejection of this idea (see Wolfram, 1969) gave way to a more general concern with subjectivity in isolating styles, so much so that, according to Rickford and McNair-Knox (1994, p. 239), “most quantitative sociolinguists came to ignore the casual/careful distinction” (see also Singler, 2007, pp. 126–127). The introduction of the Decision Tree (Labov, 2001), while providing a framework for the division of interview speech into casual and careful styles, has not been widely adopted and is admittedly subjective (p. 91). Another practical issue concerns the more formal styles, all of which rely on reading tasks. Baugh (2001, p. 110) argues that the assumption that participants are literate, and comfortably so, represents a Western bias that restricts ethnographically informed community projects, while Milroy (1987, p. 173) notes that low literacy rates in her Belfast sample ruled out the analysis of reading style.

Other critiques center on the theoretical basis of both the attention to speech mechanism and the formality continuum, and the link between them (Eckert, 2001; Milroy, 1987; Milroy & Gordon, 2003; see also Rickford & McNair-Knox, 1994, p. 239). Milroy (1987), for instance, questions whether conversational and reading styles are comparable types of behavior. Schilling-Estes (1998) points out that many performative styles, in which often a great deal of attention is paid to speech, are highly vernacular, highlighting the potential for speakers to have a range of naturalistic styles that are not controlled by the attention to speech mechanism. In light of increasing interest in style in sociolinguistics, the style as Attention to Speech model has many competitors. It is important to note, however, that Labovian contextual styles concern intra-speaker variation and should not be confused with more holistic definitions of style (Eckert, 2001). Labov (2001, p. 87) notes that the Attention to Speech model was never intended to stand as the singular mechanism governing intra-speaker variation, nor should intra-speaker variation be seen as the singular expression of speaker style.

Accepting the Attention to Speech model does not preclude other conceptualizations of style, as they are not a priori mutually exclusive. The same speaker may shift certain variables along a continuum of formality while simultaneously attending to other stylistic practices, such as accommodating to audience members (Bell, 1984) or constructing some aspect of identity (Eckert, 2001), even within the strict methodological confines of The Sociolinguistic Interview. In Becker (2009), rates of non-rhoticity for a group of Lower East Siders in New York City shifted significantly across three contextual styles: interview style, reading style, and word list style. At the same time, speakers significantly shifted rates of coda /r/ production in the body of the interview according to whether local or non-local topics were being discussed, and not according to the casual-careful distinction, a shift that was tied to the agentic construction of a place identity by those speakers.

2 *The vernacular*. Not all Labovian contextual styles are created equal. It is the least formal style, where the least attention is paid to speech, that is most valuable; this is the vernacular. The definition of the vernacular utilized here is also a narrow one, moving beyond uses that place “local” or “not standard” in opposition to terms like *standard* or *formal*. In this narrow definition, rather, the vernacular is defined in terms of how it behaves; both the speakers producing the vernacular and the system itself are considered the most natural and regular of any style. Speakers produce the vernacular when behaving most naturally and comfortably, so that it is defined, according to Labov (1972), as “the everyday speech which the informant will use as soon as the door is closed behind us: the style in which he argues with his wife, scolds his children, or passes the time of day with his friends” (p. 85). Second, we define the vernacular in terms of its own linguistic behavior: it is, or is claimed to be, the most systematic speech, ostensibly the variety first acquired in childhood. This systematicity drives our interest in privileging the vernacular in sociolinguistic investigation—what is known as the *Vernacular Principle* (Labov, 1972, p. 112).

Critiques of the vernacular as defined here do not generally reject our interest in it as an appropriate object of study (see Milroy, 1987, p. 60). Instead, concerns have been raised over the operationalization of the vernacular, as well as the value placed on it. The idea that a speaker has a way of talking that is most natural to her or him is generally not a part of the debate and is perhaps axiomatic. The problem here is that this natural variety is equated with the speech produced in the casual style of The Sociolinguistic Interview and, further, that casual speech has in almost all cases been equated with stretches of talk with the highest rates of non-standard speech. Vernacular speech is not by definition non-standard (Labov, 1984, p. 29, gives Received Pronunciation as an example of a vernacular that is a prestige variety), yet virtually all analyses of data from The Sociolinguistic Interview that seek the vernacular find it in casual speech and in non-standard forms. This three-way equating (vernacular = casual speech = non-standard usage) is highly problematic as a theoretical assumption. Schilling-Estes (2004, p. 188) presents data from situations in which low levels of non-standard variables are in fact linked to a casual style and, like Wolfson (1976) and others, urges the acknowledgment of multiple kinds of naturalistic speech.

Another critique concerns the argument that the vernacular is the most systematic of a speaker’s varieties. Again, it seems logical from the perspective of acquisition that the variety first acquired would be the most systematic. Yet, ruling out exceptional cases (second language acquisition, extremely formal self-conscious speech), it remains an empirical question whether or not some stretch of naturalistic speech is more systematic than another stretch. Crucially, no work to date has found this result for speech from within

the body of The Sociolinguistic Interview. And if it were to be shown, does this imply, as Singler (2007, p. 127) asks, that other types of naturalistic speech (careful speech, for instance) are a-systematic? In fact, given the observation above that most sociolinguists do not distinguish between careful and casual speech, it must be the case that we believe careful speech is systematic enough to quantify and analyze.

A third critique is aimed at how the notion of the vernacular is conceptualized as an entity or bounded variety (Schilling-Estes, 2007, p. 173). Researchers talk of “isolating” the vernacular, as if it were a thing that can be captured. Indeed, debates arise over the validity of sociolinguistic data where that validity relies on a claim to have obtained the vernacular when others haven’t (cf. the discussion in Rickford, 2006). Intrinsic to these debates is the equation of a bounded vernacular to high rates of non-standard production, so that the evidence for “capturing” the vernacular is a higher rate of use for a non-standard feature than found by other researchers. The higher rates, conceptualized as a captured, bounded vernacular, are then validated as real, authentic data in opposition to other data that are inauthentic. One danger of this kind of practice is the sense of some kind of a chase (for higher and higher rates that would indicate the capture of the “true” vernacular), yet one lacking an identifiable finish line. As Milroy and Gordon (2003) put it: “The difficulty in pursuing the vernacular . . . lies with the impossibility of recognizing the quarry when it is caught” (p. 50). And as Labov has noted, it is not the search for the vernacular that is problematic, it is the danger of claiming to have accessed it. He cautions: “We are forced to recognize the limitations of our other methods of eliciting the vernacular . . . [We] have defined a direction but not the destination” (1972, p. 90).

There are other dangers involved with the search for a bounded vernacular. If we expect the vernacular to be found in stretches of talk with the highest rates of non-standard features, we risk using those rates as a diagnostic of vernacular speech. Labov (1972, p. 95) notes this danger, which motivated the early proposal to use channel cues as a guide. Having now as a field rejected the use of channel cues, we may utilize the Decision Tree (Labov, 2001) to distinguish careful speech from casual (vernacular) speech, yet, as noted above, the field has not adopted this tool. Whether our analyses are in fact circular or not, I would argue that an ideological circularity pervades the field: the vernacular is whatever style has the highest rates of non-standard speech, and the highest rates of non-standard speech indicate we have “captured” the vernacular. Even in Labov (2001), where the Decision Tree is presented specifically to avoid the subjectivity and potential circularity of the casual-careful chunking, a category of residual speech (speech not categorized by a node on the tree) is posited to contain some of the vernacular *based on rates of usage*: “The fact that the Residual category is not the lowest for (DH) or (ING) makes it seem likely that there are many other Casual speech categories that can be extracted from it” (p. 107).

Another danger in seeking the vernacular is the concomitant valorization of it. Bucholtz (2003) argues that a linguist researcher assumes the role of “arbiter of authenticity” (p. 407), so that as analysts we privilege certain kinds of speakers and certain kinds of speech. Eckert (2003) argues that while the selection of “authentic speakers” is perhaps not openly discussed, the valorization of “authentic speech”—the vernacular—is proclaimed. That is, we like to tell others when we capture it: “Sociolinguists boast special methods for getting at language in its natural state. If the Authentic Speaker is an elephant hovering in the corner, the vernacular is a moose sprawling in the middle of the table” (p. 394). Milroy and Gordon (2003, p. 50) note what they call a striking similarity between the ideologized vernacular and its polar opposite, the standard. Yet they argue that, theoretically, the abstraction of the vernacular is quite beneficial as long

as the dangers as laid out here are acknowledged, and I would agree. With respect to The Sociolinguistic Interview, so much of its methodology centers on a pursuit of the vernacular. This pursuit, while fruitful, should not go unproblematicized.

The Sociolinguistic Interview in Practice

Despite its specific theoretical ends, The Sociolinguistic Interview shares much in practice with the broader set of face-to-face interviews conducted by sociolinguists. First and foremost is the focus on the elicitation of naturalistic speech and the concomitant challenge of overcoming the well-known “observer’s paradox,” defined in Labov (1972): “To obtain the data most important for linguistic theory, we have to observe how people speak when they are not being observed” (p. 113). The focus in the field on naturalistic speech serves to heighten our interest in the vernacular, so that the methodology proves to be a useful one for many sociolinguistic pursuits. In particular, a number of questions and topics (e.g., childhood games) have been noted as successful in eliciting naturalistic speech, like personal narratives.

Other techniques used as part of The Sociolinguistic Interview also inform a broader range of face-to-face data collection. One is the practice of cataloging demographic information at the beginning of the interview, as a way of creating a speaker profile for later analysis of co-variation of social and linguistic phenomena, as well as to set the tone of the speech event as a casual conversation about the interviewee’s life, experiences, and opinions. This early section further serves as transitional material from the start of the interview, where interviewees may be nervous and/or hyper-aware of recording equipment, into later topics where we hope to overcome the observer’s paradox and elicit more naturalistic speech. The training of interviewers is another area where best practices are not limited to The Sociolinguistic Interview. Honing questioning techniques (for instance, learning to move past yes/no questions to those that elicit longer narratives), controlling topic (for instance, identifying and pursuing topics of interest to the interviewee), and monitoring the presentation of self (for instance, using the tactic of playing the role of “naïve” interviewer to promote conversation and to disrupt if possible any power asymmetries between interviewer and interviewee) are all utilized in sociolinguistic fieldwork more broadly and are not limited to The Sociolinguistic Interview.

The success of The Sociolinguistic Interview as a tool for eliciting naturalistic speech has, not surprisingly, been critiqued, most notably by Wolfson (1976). Wolfson argues that The Sociolinguistic Interview is a speech event (p. 190) in which participant roles and expectations cannot in some cases and some cultures be so easily overridden by interview techniques (see also Briggs, 1986; Milroy, 1987; Milroy & Gordon, 2003; Schilling-Estes, 2007). As Eckert (2001) puts it, the issue at hand is “how well the ‘constructed stylistic world’ of the interview maps onto the larger, natural stylistic world” (p. 119). These are challenges that any recording claiming to be naturalistic should and will face; perhaps the supremacy of The Sociolinguistic Interview as used in the field has led to a well-deserved and increased scrutiny of best practices. For instance, Feagin (2002) cites several sociolinguistic studies where the classic Danger of Death question (in which interviewees are asked to recall a time in which they thought their life was threatened) was unsuccessful in encouraging interviewees to produce a long narrative using naturalistic speech. This happened in Feagin’s own research and was unsuccessful in Becker (2010) as well. An early adoption of the Danger of Death question in the field led to a later move toward reflexivity in identifying topics more broadly that are of interest to interviewees from a range of backgrounds, as well as acknowledgment of the importance

of asking pertinent questions that will elicit the emotional, engaged telling of narratives within the specific fieldwork context.

Ultimately, in practice The Sociolinguistic Interview shares much with other face-to-face naturalistic recordings, both in its best practices for eliciting naturalistic speech and in the challenges inherent in doing so. It is perhaps because of this similarity across interviewing techniques that so many techniques are referred to with the term “sociolinguistic interview.” Most face-to-face recordings may appear to “look” like The Sociolinguistic Interview (with a major exception being the presence or absence of more formal contextual styles) and will utilize many of the same methodological tools. In practice, then, there is much overlap. It is in analysis—in the goals for the data gathered—that The Sociolinguistic Interview differs greatly from the broader set of face-to-face sociolinguistic recordings.

Conclusion

Numerous scholars have noted that The Sociolinguistic Interview is not the appropriate methodological choice for many sociolinguistic studies. In some cases, this is due to the community of interest (Baugh, 2001; Briggs, 1986). In others, it is due to the variable of interest: many syntactic variables, for instance, as well as variables that hold covert prestige, can be difficult to elicit in interview situations (Milroy & Gordon, 2003; Wolfram, 2011). Yet The Sociolinguistic Interview continues to hold its place as the central methodological tool in sociolinguistics despite my argument here that, in fact, the majority of contemporary sociolinguistic studies do not utilize The Sociolinguistic Interview methodology. In Becker (2010), for instance, a three-year ethnography led to the recording of over 100 interviews with community residents on the Lower East Side of New York City. These interviews were conducted in collaboration with community partners and now reside in the community as The Seward Park Oral History Project. In designing the interviews, many methods from The Sociolinguistic Interview, including the use of topics and topic modules, were utilized, but the corpus of interviews does not abide by the strict definition presented in this chapter. Crucially, the contextual styles C–D', as well as metalinguistic commentary, were not elicited. The implication of this for sociolinguistic analysis is that investigations of change in apparent time from the perspective of the Labovian paradigm are necessarily limited due to a lack of the full range of contextual styles. Thankfully, Labov's own (1966) Lower East Side sample exists for comparison, so that the Becker (2010) data can be seen as a quasi-trend study. Yet without the elicitation of contextual styles, the interviews from Becker (2010), however valuable they may be as sociolinguistic data, do not satisfy the criteria of The Sociolinguistic Interview.

I am not suggesting that the problem is simply in the use of terminology. The many studies that refer to data from sociolinguistic interviews—when in fact those interviews do not employ the strict methodology employed here—do not necessarily need to be re-termed. Rather, we need more clarity in the field with regard to our interview techniques. To continue centralizing this method in the field, either through habit or through an expanded use of the term, obscures the underlying assumptions and the goals of the methodology. It further diminishes the contributions made by those sociolinguists who adopt these assumptions and who have used the methodology to revolutionize our understanding of linguistic variation and change.

In short, sociolinguists need to be clear about what kind of data they want and what kind of questions they want to answer before adopting a methodology. In the case of The Sociolinguistic Interview, there may be ideological pressure to adopt this method

when more general face-to-face interactions would suffice. As guides to sociolinguistic methods advise, designing a research study requires an answer to the question “What do I want to study?” If the answer falls within the Labovian variationist paradigm, then an appropriate and central methodology is The Sociolinguistic Interview.

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